

Competition for What?

Life has a way of creating new challenges, and the wealth of American life today has created its own challenges—a feeling of entitlement, of economic power, and of military might that has earned for our nation the admiration, the envy, and, yes, the hatred of much of mankind. I freely concede that the world in which our young people today are growing up is far more demanding than the more innocent world of six decades ago when I could still count myself as a youth. High schoolers double and triple up on studies, sports, and extracurricular activities so they can gain admission to the so-called best colleges. Once in college, students continue to strive for grades so they will get into the best graduate schools, and on and on the cycle of competition goes.

Up to a point, that's fine. Competition is part of life. But again I ask, competition for what? For test scores rather than learning? For form rather than substance? For prestige rather than virtue? For certainty rather than ambiguity? For following someone else's stars rather than one's own? What does all that mean if you lack honor and character? And there is the problem. For while our best and brightest are exquisitely trained to pursue the false rabbits of success, on the whole they are being poorly trained in the intangible qualities that become the virtues that bring real success.

“Without Character and Courage, Nothing Else Lasts”

In a *New York Times* essay in November 2004, David Brooks put it well:

Highly educated young people are tutored, taught, and monitored in all aspects of their lives, except the most important, which is character-building. But without character and courage, nothing else lasts.